thus, should rightfully have served as a guidance manual and should have overriden all outdated prison manuals that merely helped to serve British interests in pre-independence India. The major features of the report were that prison authorities should ensure that the human rights of prisoners are not violated. It disclosed a much larger vision in maintaining that prisons must interact with the press because it was only in this way that the work going on within them could be made authentically transparent to the world outside and society at large could keep in touch with those who have been isolated from it. Secondly, various apex court judgements directed the Tihar prison administration to implement humane methods of prison management and integrate the prisoners with the society outside.

Here, it would be relevant to quote from the report of the All-India Committee on Jail Reforms (1980–83) under the chairmanship of Justice (retired) Anand Narain Mulla (Chapter III, Section 3.45.1):

> Since time immemorial crime has been a social problem and social problems cannot be tackled merely through legislation or pronouncement of laudable objectives. Unless a large section of the society believes in the reformative and rehabilitative approaches, a progressive and modern system of prisons cannot become a reality. Public opinion has to be built up in such a way that people accept that rehabilitation of wrong-doers in society itself. This can be achieved through the education of people regarding the all-pervading implications of crime as a social and economic problem. People must be informed about the progressive and modern methods of dealing with the wrong-doers We, therefore, recommend that a regular plan aiming at creating a favourable rehabilitation culture in the society should be drawn up and implemented by the prison administration.

The press obviously had (and has) a very realistic role to play in any such educative venture and that was why print and electronic media journalists were permitted to cover the developments in Tihar so extensively.

An overview of all the charges levelled against Kiran as IG (Prisons) clearly indicated how assiduously she had pursued these very humanitarian recommendations. Also, a very interesting feature of her work methodology emerged. It strove to achieve goals and targets in keeping with those drawn up through considered opinion and purposeful deliberations condensed to policies and recommendations. In her case, the methodology was derived not through abstract considerations but rather through the management of day-to-day problems on a day-to-day basis. It was only her clarity and range of vision that directed all her efforts towards achieving the right objectives.

Her achievements at Tihar, in just one year, were precisely those recommended for American prisons after a year of deliberation and analysis by an American Correctional Reforms Committee. And, interestingly, the time period was the same. While she was working on her reforms through 1993–94, the American Committee was simultaneously deliberating over the problems facing it for the same duration. Similarly, that was exactly what she was doing without being aware of any existing recommendations that were already incorporated in the Mulla Committee report. Unfortunately, this humanistic and progressive report had almost been thrust into oblivion because the two essential qualities required for its implementation had been grossly lacking in the system: namely, commitment and effort. So, when these qualities dared to raise their heads, the system immediately closed ranks and launched into a head-on assault.

For the time being, the politicians and bureaucrats may have apparently won. The vibrant hope, however, remained that this episode represented but a small battle and the larger war still continues.